

9.3 Detailed Specific Example: Dubai, UAE



The United Arab Emirates (UAE) is comprised of seven independent emirate states, including Dubai. Dubai was established in the 19th century as a small fishing village. It developed into a regional trading hub from the early 20th century and grew rapidly in the late 20th and early 21st centuries, with a focus on tourism and the trade of luxury goods. In 2005, the UAE population was estimated at just over four million and by 2021, this had exceeded nine million.

In a short space of time, Dubai became a commercial hub with advanced technology centres. The city has a notable tech start-up sector, with major investment in research and development for advanced technology including artificial intelligence and robotics. These kinds of innovations, combined with massive investment into the region, have made Dubai a desirable location for transnational corporate headquarters, such as that of Emirates Airlines.

Dubai was once referred to as *Al Wasl*, meaning 'a connection' in Arabic. Today, Dubai connects many parts of the world with established transportation and network hubs.

TASK 1: Study Source A

Source A shows photos of Dubai. In pairs, discuss the impacts of globalisation on Dubai.



Source A: The impact on globalisation on Dubai

TASK 2

The skyline of Dubai has transformed dramatically in the last century. Today, it is a metropolis of towering skyscrapers and world-class amenities, which provide services to visitors and residents alike.

In a brief paragraph, describe how the job sector in Dubai has changed in the last 50 years. You should discuss the major changes between the sectors including the reduction in the primary sector and the increase in the secondary, tertiary, and quaternary sectors.

The impact of globalisation on Dubai

As Dubai has developed over time, the foreign population has overtaken the local population. Globalisation has posed several changes and challenges for Dubai:

305

Cultural shift

Dubai’s political regulations, legal system, and cultural values are informed by the Islamic faith. However, Dubai is more liberal than other Emirati and neighbouring countries in the region. It blends Islamic values with a high tolerance for other cultures and beliefs. For example, Dubai has fewer conservative attitudes towards its visitors’ clothing, and nightclubs, bars serving alcohol, and Western shops and brands are commonplace.

This mixing of cultures makes it much more desirable for tourists and investors, which in turn, continues to drive globalisation. However, as the majority of the city’s residents and workers are expatriates, it can be challenging for native Emiratis to preserve their language, culture, and faith. One of the ways the UAE tries to achieve this is by restricting the permanent settlement of international workers. Despite the UAE’s flexible immigration policies, there is no route to citizenship for international residents.

Environmental impacts

Globalisation has had a negative effect on Dubai’s climate. As trade, foreign investment, and tourist activity have increased, so too have significant construction projects, industrial activity, vehicle emissions, and electricity consumption from air conditioning units. Localised air pollution is a problem, particularly in the summer, impacting the quality of life for residents.

The region is also among the highest in the world for per capita water consumption. Demand for water in 2015 was approximately 16 times higher than in 1975. The region has limited natural freshwater resources and already relies on desalinated seawater to meet its demand for drinking water. As tourism and the number of residents in Dubai has expanded, the need for water desalination plants to sustain resorts and accommodation has risen. This in turn puts pressure on the surrounding land and causes degradation and further desertification in a region where water is already very scarce.

The cost of living

The cost of living in Dubai is high, with the 23rd highest monthly cost of living in the world. The average annual rent for a single-family house in Dubai rose by more than 25% from 2022 to 2023, while the average apartment rent over the same period rose by more than 25% to approximately \$27 000.

Due to the high cost of living, regional companies are compelled to offer subsidies in the form of education, travel, and housing to attract foreign workers. With a high percentage of expatriates, this further fuels the demand for housing, schooling, and health care. The positive effect of the high cost of living is therefore a continually improving quality of services and housing to retain workers, especially in the high demand tertiary and quaternary sectors.

Regulating the rights of foreign workers

The UAE relies heavily on construction workers and other labourers from countries like India, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka, and Pakistan. These workers are not always afforded the same legal protections as local employees, and as a result, the UAE has been subject to criticism from international labour advocates.

306

TASK 3: Study Source B

Source B shows two sets of data: the CO₂ emissions per capita per kilo ton in the UAE and the population size in millions, from 2010 to 2020. Using the data in Source B, answer the following questions:

a

Describe the correlation between the CO₂ emissions and the population size for the period.

b

Suggest reasons for the change in CO₂ emissions.

c

What do you think is the biggest environmental problem caused by globalisation in Dubai? You may carry out extra research to answer the question.

Year	CO ₂ emissions (metric tons per capita)	Population size (million)
2010	162 789	8.48
2011	166 632	8.57
2012	175 688	8.66
2013	184 961	8.75
2014	186 640	8.83
2015	195 409	8.91
2016	200 399	8.99

2017	191 935	9.06
2018	174 220	9.14
2019	185 646	9.21
2020	188 089	9.28

Source B: CO₂ emissions per capita per kilo tonne in the UAE, 2010–2020

TASK 4

The Dubai property market is thriving, with prices on the rise and sales increasing. This is due to several factors, including the status of Dubai as a global hub for tourism and business, the strong economy, and the attractive tax incentives for residents.

Design a pamphlet to attract investors to a newly built apartment block. Ensure to outline the positive impacts of globalisation on Dubai, and how this makes the city more desirable for investors.

307

The impact of Emirates Airline on Dubai



Figure 9.2: As of 2019, only 3% of the Emirates workforce were Emiratis

Over recent decades, the growth of the region has created a greater demand for transportation. Emirates Airlines, a TNC, was able to capitalise on this growth. In 1985, Emirates Airlines first began operating from Dubai to Karachi and Mumbai using two leased planes. Within five years, the airline grew to 14 destinations and it now runs 3600 flights a week from its hub at Dubai International Airport.

The aviation sector is an important component of the economy of Dubai, accounting for more than 30% of the GDP in 2020. Emirates Airlines, as well as their sister company Dnata, are responsible for ground handling, cargo, and travel services. As well as providing many direct job opportunities, these services have a large impact on the wider economy and support the growth of tourism and commerce in the region.

However, as of 2019, only 3% of the Emirates workforce were Emiratis. Emirates Airlines requires its cabin crew to live in Dubai and with over 20 000 staff, the TNC has had an impact on the demographics of the region. The increased number of expatriates puts pressure on housing, increasing the cost of living for local Emiratis.

The growth of the aviation industry in Dubai also brings negative environmental impacts. As the number of flights increase, so does the amount of greenhouse gases emitted. The airline has taken some steps to try address the environmental impact. For example, its transport buses for cabin crew operate on biofuel to reduce emissions. The airline also invests in local sustainability projects as part of its social corporate responsibility approach. For example, it established the Dubai Desert Conservation Reserve with the Dubai Government to protect desert habitat.